nesting lions rest with dogs

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nesting lions rest with dogs

by oldoaktree

Summary

> An annoying little voice in her head, suspiciously reminiscent of a familiar white haired man, whispered, *Mydei's obviously showing symptoms of pregnancy. He's done it, Phainon's defied biology, he's put a baby in him.*
>
> Hyacine rushed to say, “But you’ve been snacking a lot more, haven’t you? It can’t just be a regular disease, seeing as the nausea hasn't inhibited your appetite, but made it bigger.”
>
> “So you agree then,” Mydei said, and a radiant grin erupted on his face as though Hyacine had just shared brilliant news. “It is *something* within my body.”

A few months after Hyacine thinks she is finally free from third-wheeling Phainon and Mydei, Mydei falls pregnant.

Notes

> Yippee yahooey! Sorry this took so long I ended up writing more than I thought I would BUT I had to get this out after that 3.5 livestream 💔💔💔
>
> I just think phainon deserves to be a dad. Papanon and mamdei. Guys. guys can mydei get pregnant already.
>
> (Also theres like minor hyarice in the second section but highkey i forgot about it afterwards so its not in the rest of the fic)

See the end of the work for more notes

“I’ve been… unwell.”

Mydei interrupted the excited squeaks gathering around them, his voice quiet and unsure as they sat down in an isolated corner within the Garden of Life. A hoard of chimaeras, giddy at the prospect of evading their jobs to come and play with their beloved ‘Wonderful Amazing Cool Chimaera King Dei’ and ‘Miss Hyacine’, immediately began clambering all over the two, chirping and wiggling with glee.

Hyacine shuddered when tiny claws dug into her leg, a worthy sacrifice that resulted in a familiar ginger chimaera settling in her lap. Then Mydei's words registered, and she looked at him. “What?”

Her distraction elicited an unhappy little ‘awoo’ to spring from the chimaera using her as a throne, so she twiddled her fingers through its soft fur and cooed as it rolled over to show her its soft white tummy.

The two Chrysos heirs were relaxing in the Garden of Life – though if you asked Mydei, he would suggest that they were fulfilling an important mission to help boost workers’ morale – and trying to appear useful instead of merely lazing around like plump unicorns.

Ever since the departure of the Trailblazers and the end to those long, stressful months in which the progress of the Flamechase was suddenly hastened to a fantastic conclusion, Hyacine had found herself surprisingly short of work to do.

It wasn’t as if Amphoreus was completely restored to its former glory and all the threats of rogue titankin were eradicated. It wasn’t even as if Hyacine and the other Chrysos heirs had lost the golden blood that granted them enhanced ability. No, the only change was that without the black tide flowing rampant, the city was plunged into a liminal state of peace.

So here they were, playing with chimaeras and pretending that they were doing profound work.

Mydei was frowning while patting a cute little chimaera pup; its father snoozed against his thigh, eerily similar to the one that had nipped Hyacine months ago. Hyacine had to admit, he made an adorable sight, trying to look all serious and muscular while cradling a pup like his baby.

“I mean to say, I think there is something awry *within me*.” He placed stress on the end of his sentence, looking at Hyacine expectantly as if she were supposed to be a mind reader alongside a healer. She could only wish.

Hyacine gently lifted the ginger chimaera from her lap, placing it on the ground to let it waddle over to Mydei and cuddle up to the white chimaera on his thigh. “What do you mean by that? With your immortal body, I thought…” Aquila above, she was starting to sound like Phainon, always harping on about Mydei’s body.

Golden eyes were focused on the two chimaeras nestled against him, slowly shifting to the pup in his arms.

“This one… is theirs?”

“Um, probably? That white chimaera is its father; it’s particularly vicious if you try to separate them.”

Mydei nodded, understanding and *something else* lighting up in his eyes as he watched the pup with a tender gaze. Then he cleared his throat, beckoned Hyacine closer, and leaned in to speak. “My body protects me from most diseases, it’s true, but lately, I’ve been feeling strange.” He raised a hand to fiddle with his braid. “I’ve been drowsier than usual, and somewhat nauseous.”

The fatigue shouldn’t have been a major cause of concern, seeing as Mydei was already prone to taking frequent naps during the day. Hyacine could easily recall at least twenty-seven instances in which a civilian had stumbled across the slumbering man, accidentally awoken him, and come begging to Hyacine to grant them protection from the ‘enraged lion’.

Though anyone could tell that Mydei was less of an ‘enraged lion’ when stirred from his naps, but rather, a ‘confused kitten’. Phainon’s words, not Hyacine’s. He had once spent an entire Lucid hour regaling his favourite positions, locations and outfits that he had caught Mydei napping in around Okhema. Hm, *no*, actually, Hyacine didn’t want to remember that.

Moving on. Mydei’s nausea, however, could be a problem – it was usually a sign of internal imbalance and could suggest something was wrong, not to mention the risk of malnutrition from a suppressed appetite. For a man as reliant on his physical state as Mydei, frequent nausea was certain to be a curse.

Yet strangely enough, despite nausea often inhibiting hunger, Mydei had been displaying a completely different effect. From what Hyacine had seen of Mydei their last few encounters, stolen glimpses of the prince tucked away in a corner with a platter of sweets in hand, or greeting him at the baths while Phainon was feeding him grapes as though he were a spoiled housecat, a common denominator remained – the snacking.

An annoying little voice in her head, suspiciously reminiscent of a familiar white haired man, whispered, *Mydei's obviously showing symptoms of pregnancy. He's done it, Phainon's defied biology, he's put a baby in him.*

Hyacine smacked her palm to her head. Ha, what a thought.

Ignoring Mydei's confused face, his jaw dropped at her reaction, Hyacine rushed to say, “But you’ve been snacking a lot more, haven’t you? It can’t just be a regular disease, seeing as the nausea hasn't inhibited your appetite, but made it bigger.”

“So you agree then,” Mydei said, and a radiant grin erupted on his face as though Hyacine had just shared brilliant news. “It is *something* within my body.”

“Perhaps you’ve been working too hard? Cassie mentioned that you keep taking missions, even though there’s really no need…”

To be honest, it wasn't that there was a lack of need for Mydei's help – he was invaluable in clearing up the leftover corrupted titankin, as well as leading Okhema's expeditionary forces into the newly cleansed land. Rather, Mydei's dedication to rebuilding and repopulating the fallen Amphorean cities seemed to border on obsession.

Mydei frowned, his hands balling on the ground beside him. “Only because Phainon never lets me do anything. He treats me like a princess locked in a tower, always trying to do everything before I even lift a finger.” He started tugging at the grass, repeatedly plucking and dropping it on the white chimaera’s back. “I mean, he doesn't even want me cleaning up around the house anymore.”

That didn’t sound so bad to Hyacine. It was like complaining that the grass was too green, the sky was too blue, the chimaeras too cute. She would love to have someone helping her with her chores, clearing up messes and sorting out her neverending to-do lists without a word. Instead she had Ica.

“He says he ‘needs to pamper his wife’, but I’m so bored. And now I’m sick.”

Phainon was probably still in the honeymoon phase, eager to please Mydei and prove himself to be a worthy match. Hyacine could remember that was exactly how he had behaved during their first year at the Grove, all polite and friendly like an obedient puppy, even if their professor asked him to do the most mundane tasks.

She could imagine the man flitting around their house with a broom in hand, happily sweeping the floors and wiping the counters and doing the laundry. Her eyes focused on the white chimaera, its eyes half-open as it let Mydei unconsciously cover it in grass.

“Just yesterday, he tried cooking dinner.”

Scratch that, it wasn’t a honeymoon phase, Phainon was trying to kill Mydei.

“Could it be food poisoning?” Hyacine had firsthand experience with the man’s cuisine, and she had had to prepare an antidote for it immediately afterwards. “I hate to say it, but Phainon’s cooking isn’t exactly–”

“His cooking’s abysmal, even red soil tastes better than his bread,” Mydei said, waving a hand in dismissal as if that would conceal the dromas in the room.

“Mydei,” Hyacine began slowly, “Mydei, have you been eating dromas feed?”

Even Ica didn’t touch that.

“That’s not the point, I’ve been feeling off for longer than his weird protectiveness has started.” There was a slight flush to Mydei’s cheeks as he tapped his chin in thought. “Maybe about a month or so.”

A month?! By Aquila, Hyacine needed to step up her game if her patients were waiting a *month* to tell her of their sickness.

She was about to speak, her physician's persona switching on in preparation for a *full* breakdown of Mydei's symptoms, when a pair of hands covered his golden eyes.

"Guess who!"

Hyacine's day could not get any worse.

Mydei chuckled and pulled one of the hands down to plant a gentle kiss to the palm. Then he leaned back, golden eyes meeting blue as he gave Phainon a disgustingly tender look. Hyacine's day got worse.

It wasn't even as if she hated their relationship; on the contrary, she appreciated their love. Sure, she wasn't a diehard fan of the two men like Castorice, nor a general supporter of romance like Aglaea, but she could appreciate the beauty and strength of the bond they shared.

It's just, she would prefer if they didn't display that bond so *blatantly* in front of her.

And clearly, she had a supporter in this belief.

The white chimaera, previously seated so peacefully beside Mydei, crouched on its haunches, leaped up with an enraged 'awoo' and snapped at Phainon's shin, eliciting a shrill yelp as the man toppled over. Hyacine blinked. She didn't think even *her* voice could reach that pitch.

Then, while Phainon lay in a heap on the ground, the chimaera stood on its hind legs to pluck its white-haired baby from Mydei's arms, securing the pup in its mouth to deposit it under the ginger chimaera's paw and huddle together once more.

Mydei only watched the exchange with an amused silence, waiting for the chimaera family to settle down before turning to pull his unruly husband up off the floor.

Like a petulant child, Phainon was *pouting*, and he sniffed dramatically as he rested his chin on Mydei's bare shoulder. "Mydeiii," he whined, "I got attacked."

He was a grown man.

Phainon, a formidable warrior capable of battling with Titans and scratching cosmic entities from even outside the boundaries of Amphoreus' existence, was acting like a child over a little nip from a chimaera.

"Don't be a baby, Deliverer." Mydei chided, but he still turned his head to press a soft kiss to Phainon's cheek and tangled his fingers in snowy hair.

Hyacine's face twisted in disgust, outraged at the sickeningly sweet display of affection she was being forced to witness. Though unfortunately, the others were too lost in each other's presence to notice her metaphorical foaming at the mouth.

“What's it gonna take for you to give me a more loveable nickname?” Came a mournful sigh as Phainon wrapped his arms around Mydei's waist to settle his palms on his stomach. Hyacine noticed the blond perk up slightly at that. “Maybe ‘honey’, or ‘sweetheart’, or ‘darling’… hey, you call me ‘husband’ so sweetly when we–”

She actually didn't want to hear that. It was honestly baffling how it seemed that they would save their most sappy conversations for when she was around, like they were taking every chance they could go make her feel wildly out of place.

In the centre of their little gathering, the culprit behind Phainon's attack sat peacefully, having trotted over to Hyacine once the blubbering started. It rolled over and showed her its fluffy white tummy, inviting her to stroke.

Well, she wasn't going to complain.

“I think ‘Deliverer’ is a loveable nickname though? It's for you,” Mydei said, drawing her out of her thoughts, “and I love you.” He spoke frankly, like he was telling Phainon something so *obvious* he had not expected to have to spell it out.

Hyacine could only watch in horror as Phainon's eyes widened, his cheeks pinked and he leaped forward to knock Mydei over onto the grass with a squeal of, “Oh Mydei!”

“Wha– get off me!”

And then, as if their *canoodling* wasn't enough, the two men started grappling like children, rolling in the grass and muddying themselves with clear grins stretched across their faces.

Even the chimaera family were wary of the scene, the ginger one lifting up its pup by the scruff and hastily trotting away while the white one guarded its back with suspicion, eyeing the tussling men like some strange, obscene new threat.

Maybe Hyacine should follow their lead.

Hyacine ducked as the titankin swung towards her with a solid mace, her hat flying off of her head and landing on the ground right next to its feet. She eyed it in despair when the titankin lifted its stone foot, about to sully the fabric with its slimy secretions, until a blur of lilac flashed into sight.

Castorice swung her scythe into the titankins midriff and with a burst of flowers, it crumbled into dust and buried the hat under a grey pile. Oh well, dust was easier to clean than slime.

The two Chrysos heirs were a little ways outside Okhema on a mission to clear up the random resurgence of corrupt titankin bothering the farmers. To do so, Tribbie had supplied them with a purification totem, which they had to plant on a suitable point in order to create a safe zone from any further disturbance.

Thankfully, Hyacine had been paired with Castorice, so she didn't have to worry about the fighting. The woman fought with intense vigour and yet remained calm, as if she were merely plucking the petals from a flower – beautiful and deadly.

Even Ica, hurtling into the titankin with strikes of brute force, didn't look as composed.

“Cassie, we make a great pair, huh?” Hyacine called out, her eyes twinkling and bright at the sight of the demigod slicing through titankin like an angel of death. She kept all their attention on her, leaving Hyacine free to plant the totem in the ground.

Except when she heard those words, something strange happened: a wash of pink flooded Castorice’s face.

Wow.

Luckily, she had destroyed most of the titankin surrounding them, for she stood frozen in place, her cheeks adorably flushed and her eyes wide with an unnameable emotion. Hyacine watched with interest as her fingers flexed and unflexed around the handle of her scythe, her lips slightly parted around a sudden intake of breath.

Then there was an enraged screech right next to Hyacine’s ear – a titankin had snuck up on her, pot-bellied and roaring with fury, its hand drawn back and poised to strike with a golden goblet.

Castorice was too far to reach it in time, and Hyacine's eyes squeezed shut as she braced her core to tank the hit; sure, she wasn't *Mydei*, capable of walking off stab wounds and broken limbs like they were merely insect bites, but she wasn't a Chrysos heir for nothing.

The blow never landed. Instead, all Hyacine heard was a shrill, “Brrrt!”

Her eyes snapped open. Ica, brilliant Ica, had locked in on the opponent and zoomed forward to knock it backwards, creating enough distance for Hyacine to scramble to the side while the tiny unicorn faced off with the titankin.

Castorice gasped out an apology and darted forward, raising her hand and tapping the titankin lightly on the chest to kill it in an instant. Her gaze was narrowed, her normally kind violet eyes filled with a sliver of annoyance.

Woah, Hyacine thought with a smile broadening on her face, *Cassie looked quite… cool.*

“Ah, Miss Hyacine, watch out!”

It seemed that the titankin was not a normal one – Hyacine should have been able to tell based on its potbelly swinging around and the goblet in its hand. Unfortunately, she hadn’t noticed and, with that dazed grin still plastered on her face, she hadn’t moved out of the line of fire.

There was a grotesque noise as the titankin exploded, its pink slimy innards bursting directly all over Hyacine and covering her in a foul-smelling heap of mush.

Still, Hyacine was a little distracted by the worried expression on Castorice's face, her arm outstretched as if to try to protect Hyacine from the blast. Oh, she was too cute.

Then a sizeable drop of goop dripped into Hyacine's eye and she let out a screech.

"Miss Hyacine!" Hasty footsteps rushed towards her, and the telltale feeling of drowsiness that accompanied Castorice's presence began to take over Hyacine's body.

Realising her mistake, the footsteps stopped, followed by an upset, "Ah, my apologies!"

"Doot doot!" A familiar plump snout nudged Hyacine's arm as Ica grabbed her sleeve, tugging her forward.

"Ica, you'll guide me?"

"Brrt!"

"I think it's best that we head straight to the baths, Miss Hyacine." Castorice's voice was heavy with regret – she was most likely distressed at seeing her covered in titankin slime – but she spoke louder than usual so that she could be heard through the gunk blocking Hyacine's ears. "I don't know what sort of titankin that was, but it can't be safe to have its… *secretions* all over you."

Even in the horrid situation she was in, Hyacine felt giddy over the worry in her voice. "Heh, not to worry, Cassie. I think that was just one of Phagousa's Scions. They're gross, but harmless."

Phagousa's Scions were a derivative of titankin that hailed from Styxia, old drunkards that fought using goblets of slime and exploded into slop once defeated. Professor Anaxa had brought one of them into a lecture once, rambling about experimenting on how to kill them without getting covered in their innards.

Suffice to say, after that class, the Grove's communal showers were full.

Hyacine bemoaned her fate. She could remember how intensely she had had to scrub to get the slime off her clothes, though at least it had blended in with her hair – Phainon's head was stained pink for a whole week.

Thankfully, the walk to the baths wasn't too long, and Ica made for a surprisingly good guide. Probably because they had a large surface area.

It was fairly late in the day as well; the last Hyacine had checked, it was around the fourth quint of Parting hour, so most citizens would be at home enjoying dinner with their families. The only people on the streets were the vendors packing up and the partygoers getting started on their nightly trysts.

Quietly, Hyacine, Ica and Castorice made their way into the Marmoreal Palace.

"Watch your step, Miss Hyacine. We're at the lift," Castorice warned, and Hyacine passed her a grateful smile.

“Thanks, Cassie,” She carefully lifted her foot to climb on, “You know, you don’t have to call me ‘Miss Hyacine’. Makes me feel like one of my stuffy old lecturers. Just Hyacine is fine.”

There was a silence as Castorice got on the lift behind her. And then, in a teasing voice “Oh? But, Lady Tribios gets to call you Cinny.”

If Hyacine could see, and if she wasn’t panicking over the fact that Castorice – sweet, serious Castorice – was *teasing* her, she might have caught the woman pressing her palms to her face in an attempt to cover the furious blush swarming her delicate features.

But unfortunately, the titans hated her.

Hyacine was about to respond, about to tell her that yes, *of course* she could call her Cinny, or any nickname she liked, when the sound of voices drifted down from above.

“I wonder who’s up here so late.”

Even Aglaea didn’t tend to bathe this late in the day, spending her evenings placidly sewing and consolidating her orders for the day. Hyacine couldn’t think of a time when she had set foot in the baths at this time, always busy clearing up the medical bay after a day of work.

“...wait,” Castorice said, her voice filled with a subtle excitement. “What time is it?”

“Uh,” It was a good thing teleslates were accessible for the blind, as Hyacine could check the time with just a press of the button on the side. “Fifth quint of Parting hour?”

There was a squeak beside her, but it was quickly covered by a cough.

Ok.

The moving platform stopped in place, finally at the top, but Hyacine had no room for relief when she heard who the mysterious voices belonged to.

“Calm down, Mydei, I just want to cuddle,” Came a familiar voice, followed by a splash of water and the noise of skin-on-skin, as though arms had wrapped around someone in a hug.

“You never *just* want to cuddle, the last time–” The angry words were cut off by a disgusted gasp, voicing the feeling Hyacine was trying hard to suppress inside.

The sound of water rippling and hitting the edge of the baths drifted to Hyacine’s ears as someone stood up, the gentle patter of feet on the tiles following as they approached.

“Lord Mydei, Lord Phainon.” Castorice greeted.

Phainon’s voice sounded constipated when he said, “Castorice, Hyacine! You guys are back!”

“It's good to see you, Castorice,” Mydei’s voice was closer than she realised, and he took Hyacine’s hand gently as he guided her to the bath in place of Ica. “What in Nikador’s name happened to you, Hyacine?”

When they were in the water, Hyacine stood in place awkwardly as Mydei began rubbing at her face, dedicatedly scrubbing away at the goop and mess left behind by the titankin. Hyacine felt like a baby chimaera being groomed by its mother.

“Um,” She wasn’t about to mention the fact that she had been distracted by Castorice’s blush, “We ran into one of Phagousa’s Scions.”

“Phagousa's Scions? I thought they kept to Styxia. I remember one of Professor Anaxa's lectures on the site fidelity of titankin based on their corresponding Titan,” Phainon called out, and then there was a contemplative silence before he continued. “D’you think maybe they're migrating?”

Hyacine wasn’t really in the mood to think. Mydei’s hands were firm but gentle, and she was feeling sleepy under his ministrations as he washed her. Though, perhaps that was an important thing to think about, seeing as abnormal titankin could cause more harm then good.

There was a rinse of water over her face, and then finally, *finally*, Hyacine could see again!

She wished she couldn’t. Upon opening her eyes, she was immediately faced with the view of Mydei’s focused gaze as he directed his attention to cleaning her hair, and over Mydei’s shoulder, Phainon’s loving eyes staring dreamily at the blond’s face.

The whole bath was empty, and Phainon just *had* to stand plastered to Mydei like a limpet.

Hyacine wanted to look away from the men in front of her, only to catch sight of fabric slipping off of pale skin as Castorice undressed. Yeah, no, she would have to look at the floor.

But the floor was no better, as on the pile of discarded clothes was her hat, slightly dusty, but in good condition. Hyacine had to hold back a squeal – Castorice had picked it up for her and carried it safely all the way.

Then she remembered Phainon had asked a question, and hastily responded, “I guess, maybe. Honestly, I'm not too certain.”

“Hmph, don't worry about that too much, you did a good job today.” Once Mydei was done mothering Hyacine, he patted a hand on her rosy locks and grabbed Phainon’s wrist to tug him back to their corner and shove him in place. Then, like a king on his throne, Mydei sat on the man’s lap.

To add to the regal image, Phainon was even feeding him pomegranate seeds from a small platter, ignoring the beady eyes watching them. Ica was hungry.

Before she could think about what she was saying, too drained from the day and distracted with slipping on her bathing robe, Hyacine said, “Mydei, you shouldn't snack so late in the day, it can lead to more nausea and stomach discomfort.”

Normally, the man would be appreciative of her knowledge on aspects such as this – he treated his body like a temple and stayed away from keeping unhealthy habits, accentuating the importance of a good diet.

Out of the corner of her eye, Hyacine saw Phainon go pale, desperately waving a hand at her as if to tell her to stop. But it was too late.

“Actually, you look a little bloated. Should I give you a digestive tonic?”

Hyacine really didn’t mean to hurt his feelings. In the past, Mydei had always accepted them with a smile, or even *asked* for the tonics himself when his stomach was feeling off.

But it was like she had kicked a chimaera. For a moment, Mydei’s eyes widened, stunned, and then they were filled with tears as he warbled in a heartbroken voice, “Do I?”

“No, of course not, Dei, Hyacine’s just joking!” Phainon rushed to fix the damage, cuddling Mydei into his chest and hiding his face as he placed a conspicuous finger over his lips to tell Hyacine to be quiet.

She wasn’t joking about the bloating, but ok.

“Ahaha, Hyacine got whacked in the head by that titankin earlier, she's not in her right mind.” Castorice’s words were a *betrayal*, but Hyacine couldn’t find it in her to be mad at how she had her familiar notebook out, making notes. She really wondered what she wrote there. Then violet eyes were fixed on her, expecting her to do something to comfort the sniffling man in Phainon’s lap, and Hyacine panicked.

She did the first thing she could think of. She threw Ica at Mydei.

“Doot doot!” Mydei's pupils dilated as he watched the white blur sail towards him, and he caught Ica with one hand to cuddle up to them with a delighted noise.

The tears were gone, dried up in the prospect of being able to hold Ica (even as Phainon’s breath left him in a swift exhale as the weight on his lap drastically increased). Ica, however, only looked mournfully at the pomegranate seeds left on the platter beside them, unable to stretch out and steal them.

Hyacine finally slipped back into the bath to enjoy the peaceful silence that came with bathing so late in the day. Too exhausted from the day, no one said a word. All she could hear was the rippling of golden water, Castorice’s steady breaths, and–

“Phainon, my chest hurts.”

She could only watch in despair as Castorice’s breath sped up, her posture becoming rapt with attention as Phainon gave an indulgent hum and started massaging Mydei’s chest with reverent hands.

While it was a well-known fact that Phainon and Mydei were relatively shameless when it came to skinship, it was surprising to see how… *innocent* Phainon’s touches were, focused solely on relieving pain.

He chuckled, his hands pressing down near Mydei’s sternum. “Honey, aren't you shy, admitting that in public like this?”

Ugh. Pet names.

Mydei blinked one eye open lazily. “Why should I be? I imagine Castorice is well-versed in matters such as these, and Hyacine already knows of my condition.” He shot her a knowing look, as if she were in on some secret that she had *no idea about*. “Besides, there’s nothing to be shy about; they're practically family.”

It was truly adorable how comfortable Mydei had become over the years, going so far as to see them all as family. While Hyacine, Castorice and Phainon had all at least shared their education in the Grove, bonding over last-minute essays and early-morning lectures, Mydei had spent his youth mostly in turmoil – be it drowning in the Sea of Souls, leading his detachment and plundering cities, or overthrowing his father.

Now, with the newfound peace on Amphoreus, there was finally time for them to relax and bond as a *family*.

But something Mydei said had struck a chord in Hyacine – his ‘condition’ that Hyacine supposedly already knew of, and Castorice had experience in.

To name the facts: Mydei had been tired lately, was snacking more, was behaving more protectively, was quick to get emotional and had a *swell* to his stomach. And Castorice, as the demigod of Thanatos, was not only capable of sensing death, but also *life*.

Hyacine’s eyes widened. She looked at Mydei. At the softness in his hips, his chest, his stomach. The curve to his belly, slight enough to be mistaken for bloating but unmistakably there.

No. No way.

With Mydei distracted in conversation with Castorice, Hyacine took her chance and pulled Phainon aside, the sheer distress evident on her face. “Phainon, do you remember that day a few months ago, when you were announcing your marriage and you made that… request.” *That* request, of roping Hyacine into researching methods to defy biology. “Did you somehow follow through with that?”

The man took a moment to respond, holding his chin and frowning deeply in thought. Then he brightened, lighting up as he said, “Oh, I remember! Mydei let me braid his hair for the first time that day,” That was great, but Hyacine didn’t ask. “Ah, but I could only wish. Castorice was the only one willing to help, and our ideas fizzled out pretty quickly.”

He leaned back against the mouth of the baths and snuck an affectionate glance to the side at the blond, like a clingy puppy.

“I asked Prof, but he just laughed and told me to pick up a book on Kremnoan biology” Phainon let out a disbelieving laugh. “I'm not sure why he would recommend a book when I could study it hands-on,” Aquila above, not another tangent. “Like, did you know that Mydei has an erogenous spot right above–”

Hyacine didn’t need to be a debate champion to point out the multiple flaws in his argument.

One: Phainon's only frame of reference was Mydei, too small of a sample size to represent the entire Kremnoan population.

Two: Phainon's only frame of reference was Mydei, and considering his golden blood and immortality, the man was an anomaly compared to other Kremnoans. Even if some Kremnoans were a bit strange in their own right.

Three: Phainon's only frame of reference was Mydei, and Mydei was known for lying about things to get Phainon's attention. To name an example, Hyacine had once caught him feigning an injured shoulder to get Phainon to carry his supplies when on an expedition, and then *twisting his own ankle* so that Phainon would sweep him up and carry him home.

When Hyacine had asked him about it, Mydei had just cleared his throat and looked away, his ears burning bright red, and muttered, "I didn't do it on purpose."

She had seen him do it, a toothy grin on his face. He had done it on purpose.

"And! Another thing I discovered, just yesterday. You see his braid? When I tugged on it, he *squeaked* and then his–"

"That's great, Phainon, but Mydei is showing textbook signs of pregnancy." Hyacine wanted to tear her hair out. If Mydei was actually pregnant, then she was done for. "The cravings, the soreness and now the bump."

"Eh? Really?" An absentminded voice. Phainon wasn't paying attention to her, his eyes once again tracing the lines of Mydei's smile.

Hyacine snapped her fingers in front of him to break his trance, saying, "Focus! When was the last time you guys had unprotected sex?"

"Um." Phainon's face turned red. "Half a quint ago?"

She must have sinned. A grievous sin, so terrible that the titans were now punishing her and making her rue the day she was born. The titans hated Hyacine. They wanted her gone, melted into a mural in the sky and struck down every week in a form of eternal punishment.

"Haha, don't worry about it, Hyacine!" Phainon laughed, clapping her on the shoulder with hands that had probably been places she *did not* want to know about. "Without assistance, how could a man get pregnant? I'm dedicated, but not superhuman."

Hyacine should put those words on his grave.

As Okhema's Head Physician, Hyacine's job made her proficient in multiple areas of the medical field. One moment she could be doing basic first aid on a child's broken leg, the next

moment she would be conducting delicate surgeries on a soldier's punctured lung, maybe the next, she would be helping to deliver a child.

And today, she was looking after a postnatal patient.

"Now, you want to place your baby against your shoulder and pay lightly on her back," She demonstrated on Ica, her muscles straining as she lifted them over her shoulder and thumped on their back.

The baby's father copied her, looking after his child while the mother took some well-needed rest on the kline beside them. His motions were hesitant, but correct, and the baby let out a tiny burp after a brief moment – thankfully, with no vomit.

"Perfect! I'll leave you guys here to rest now."

Hyacine left the room, humming cheerfully to herself as she slipped off her apron and hung it beside the door. Having completed her patient rounds early, she now had some long-needed free time to go out for her lunch break, maybe grab something from Kyros' pub, and if she was lucky, enjoy her food with the chimaeras under the sunlight.

She wasn't lucky.

Pushing through the curtains separating the rooms with the foyer, Hyacine was immediately met with the sight of Phainon, one arm curled around Mydei's shoulders to pull him close to his chest, while his free hand was balancing Hyacine's jar of sweets in front of their faces.

The jar of sweets was a tool she used in a game to challenge patients to guess how many pieces were in the jar. It came with the promise of a reward if guesses were right and it was aimed at limiting disturbances in the clinic through distracting nervous children. Well, nervous children, and Chrysos heirs, it seemed.

"Don't be silly, Mydei, there's clearly three hundred and twelve candies in the jar," Phainon said, his voice taking on an insufferable tone as he shook the jar.

Mydei scoffed, wrestling out of Phainon's hold to snatch the jar from his hand. Interestingly, he wasn't in his usual outfit, having swapped it for a red chiton with more coverage instead. His hair was pulled back in a lengthy braid, long enough to brush the curve of his waist, and adorned with familiar flowers from the Garden of Life. He had probably been playing with the city's children again.

"HKS, the jar is rectangular," He measured the jar in his hands, "and the sides are thirteen by twenty four," Hyacine could see the cogs turning in his head, "so clearly that's *two* hundred and twelve."

The cogs were clearly malfunctioning.

"You're both wrong." They startled when Hyacine spoke, nearly dropping the jar if not for Ica swooping in to save the day. "You're failing to account for the sweets Ica stole while I was

filling the jar. And, anyway, that's a game to entertain kids, why are you thinking so much about it?"

Abashed, Mydei looked away. "Hmph, it's a stupid game."

"Sure, Mydei. What can I do for you two today?" The couple both looked to be in good health, so the only reasons they could be visiting Hyacine were if the problem was internal, if they simply wanted to chat, or worst of all…

Please don't be a sex thing, she prayed, her smile twitching on her face.

"My morning sickness has subsided, and I think the baby has settled now. We wanted to get prenatal scans done."

What.

Hyacine's smile was frozen on her face. Surely she hadn't heard that right. Right?

Nobody moved. The room was silent.

Phainon's teasing expression dropped, his face drained of colour as he watched Mydei with the horror of someone who had just been told their whole life was a simulation. Slowly, he sank to his knees.

Hyacine was no better, her mind sprinting to come up with something to say but falling short. Aquila save her.

Golden eyes darted their focus between them, Mydei's brow furrowing as he placed a hand protectively over his belly. His belly, which Hyacine could see, was more obviously rounder. "What're those faces for?"

"You're *pregnant*?!" Two voices shrieked, and Hyacine's gaze snapped to the man kneeling on the floor in confusion.

"Why are *you* surprised?"

Phainon stumbled forward on his knees, reaching forward to grab onto Mydei and gasping out, "Shit, I didn't know– Mydei, you're not messing with me? You're actually pregnant?"

His shock only fuelled his husband's anger, and Mydei shoved him away. "HKS, you can't be serious! I told you I was carrying!"

"Wha– I thought you meant in the fight!" Phainon was pulling at his hair."You told me that *while we were up against titankin*," and then he rose back to his feet to pace on the spot.

Mydei's voice was one of utter disbelief. "I told you I wanted kids?! What was your plan going to be then?"

"*I don't know*, I was just gonna keep fucking you until you got pregnant."

“Can you not have these conversations in front of me like this.”

But Hyacine's words went unnoticed, lost as the two men were in each other's eyes. Phainon had grabbed onto Mydei's arm and pulled him close, unconsciously stroking along tattooed skin to soothe the man as he steadied his breathing.

“Mydei, is this what you meant in the Garden of Life?” Hyacine called out, and Mydei nodded. “But… how?”

With a long suffering sigh, Mydei went to sit down, yanking Ica away from opening the candy jar and squeezing the unicorn between his arms for emotional support before saying, “Kremnoan royalty have slightly different biology to the average citizen. The history behind the phenomenon is long and too much to explain in simple conversation, but essentially, the first king of Kremnos, Gorgo, had a male lover, and so was blessed by Nikador with the ability to carry his child so as to not let his bloodline die out.”

Phainon had migrated to his side and had wrapped his arms reverently around Mydei's middle, clear blue eyes focused on the swell of his stomach as it rose and fell with each breath.

Frankly, the news felt liberating to Hyacine. No longer was she suffering through people calling her *crazy*, ignoring Mydei's evident symptoms: the cravings, the baby bump and even his hair, shinier and longer than ever.

Only, as she stood there thinking, dread started pooling in her mind. Mydei was pregnant.

And if Mydei was pregnant, then that meant Phainon was going to be a *father*.

That would mean Phainon was going to get even more annoying!

The man in question stuck his finger into Mydei's collar, pulling it forward to look down the gap and remark, “Oh, that explains why your nipples have been puffier lately.”

“Don’t just look down my chiton like that,” came a flat voice, but Mydei didn't pull away and only squeezed Ica tighter.

Hyacine had forgotten Mydei was just as shameless as his husband.

“Um. Do you still want that scan done?”

Phianon looked up eagerly, “Yes please!”

At his words, Ica started trying to escape Mydei's grasp, squealing and struggling against the barrier of his arms until they were finally free to zoom off into a corridor, nothing but a round white blur. In response to Mydei's confusion, Hyacine only said, “Oh, Ica’s in charge of all the fancy tech. They have a natural aptitude for that sort of stuff.”

Ica returned, hauling along a device the size of Hyacine; the scanning machine wasn't a complex thing, just a screen with a command board and a detachable handheld scanner, but

somehow, it had ended up a hugely inconvenient thing to drag around, and so Ica's support was needed to easily transport it.

“Alright, Mydei, if you’ll pull down your chiton for me, and lie back.” Hyacine said as she switched on the scanner, pulling out a tub of gelatinous fluid to spread onto Mydei's stomach.

As she rubbed the gel onto the bump – awfully prominent now, causing Hyacine to wonder just *how* Phainon had failed to acknowledge it – an arm snaked around Mydei's shoulders to cover his chest.

Hyacine looked at Phainon unamused. He looked back, a crooked smile stretching across his lips. Whatever, she had a job to do.

Moving the handheld scanner across Mydei's belly, she began to point on the screen. “Here is your womb,” Phainon squeezed the arm around Mydei slightly at her words, forcing Hyacine to hold back a grimace. “And I think,” she zoomed in, “Right here. This is your baby.”

On the screen, the glowing white outline of a fetus was visible – a clear head and curled up body, looking perfectly healthy. Based on the size, Hyacine assumed that Mydei was around three months along, and she immediately started drafting a little pregnancy guide in her head, taking notes of Mydei's symptoms and his condition.

Quiet sniffling interrupted her thoughts, and Hyacine turned to see Phainon, his eyes and nose tinged red as he desperately tried to hold back tears. Mydei, on the other hand, was calm, a proud glimmer in his eyes as he watched the screen.

Cuddled up together like that, the two men made an adorable sight, all excited and emotional over the prospect of their little family growing.

And then–

“Wait, Hyacine, we’ve been having sex like normal, could that have hurt the baby?!”

She wanted them *out*.

At the Grove, an unspoken rule was that great things could be accomplished at any hour, regardless of how unconventional. After all, the scholars were followers of Cerces, not Oronyx, so why should they constrain themselves to trivial concepts such as time?

And if they didn't bother themselves with time, why should they bother themselves with *sleep*?

One of the scholars had developed an increasingly potent brew of coffee, deep and dark and fragrant, strong enough to keep drinkers awake for days at a time with only one cup.

Professor Anaxa was a strong proponent of the coffee, and Hyacine swore she had never seen that man sleep in all her years of schooling.

In any case, a jug of that coffee sat on the table in Anaxa's office amidst haphazard files and papers thrown in disarray. Hyacine was already on her second cup, helping her to stay up all night until now, the fourth quint of Curtain-fall hour.

As hilarious as it sounded for people with such great responsibilities, the two were holed up in Anaxa's office, *grading midterm papers*.

"Ridiculous…" Hyacine heard the professor mutter, scribbling a large red circle on a paper, "These ideas are rudimentary at best. They have no innovation and no creativity – just the same recycled concepts."

At least he had a proper exam. Hyacine was grading 'My Professor Who Is Secretly An Omega!' and trying very hard not to grimace at every allusion to Anaxa as an… omega. Whatever that meant.

Looking over to the remaining stack of papers, Hyacine felt a pang of dread. They were going to be here for a while.

At least it was only the professor keeping her company. Many would argue that the man was insane, a veritable 'mad scientist' who valued research over even his own life and would sacrifice his firstborn for a renovated lab, but, Hyacine had long since gotten used to Anaxa's eccentric nature.

She had learnt that the best way to appease him was to just let him ramble to himself, taking the part of a silent listener for him to bounce ideas off of. She didn't have to think, and she didn't have to talk, her attention focused solely on the mindless grading of papers.

"Professor, do you know if you have– oh, hey Hyacine."

Aquila above.

The door to the office creaked open, Phainon standing in the doorway with deep-set circles under his eyes and a yawn threatening to escape his lips. With a basket on one arm and his mismatched set of clothes (a pair of green trousers, an orange shirt, and odd shoes over one sock), he looked like a fashion nightmare. Aglaea would be glad she never set foot in the Grove.

Yet, there was no mistaking the glitter in his eyes, the true mark of a man delighted to be on his mission.

"Phainon. What is it?" Anaxa's voice was uninterested, and he didn't even look up from his desk – this was clearly a frequent occurrence.

Before answering the man, Phainon made a beeline for the coffee and chugged it down straight from the jug. Heathen. Then, he cleared his throat. "Would any of you know where I

might find," He pulled a list out from his pocket, "cloudsheep, hornswine, wheat porridge and pomegranate bark?"

"Pomegranate bark. Like, from a tree?" Hyacine was stumped. Was Phainon trying to do alchemy? Why did he need such an array of substances?

Phainon nodded. "I guess so. Mydei woke me up, saying the baby wanted it."

"Right," That wasn't much better than alchemy. "It's just, I'm not sure how safe it is for Mydei to be chewing on trees."

"Please, if the baby's anything like its parents, then it'll be fine," came Anaxa's annoyed mutter as he jabbed his pen onto a page, and Phainon whipped his head around in offence.

"Our baby is not an *'it'*!"

He puffed up, ready to start debating the professor, but Hyacine really couldn't take him seriously with his outfit – the man looked like a pumpkin on a picnic.

"You could probably find wheat porridge and pomegranate bark in Okhema," She tapped her chin in thought and leaned back in her chair as she spoke. "As for the hornswine and cloudsheep… I'm not too sure, but maybe you could ask Ica?"

There was a confident "Brrrt!", and then Ica was already fluttering out of the room.

"Thank you!"

As quickly as he had entered, Phainon left the room.

Hyacine rubbed her forehead with a sigh, pointing her gaze back to the exam in front of her. Time to get back to work.

***

Guiding Phainon to the flock of cloudsheep and the herd of hornswine was easy for Ica. Ica could locate any food from any place, and any era, even if it had been lost to the annals of time.

Maybe Ica should have let Phainon return home *alone* with his spoils, to dote on his wife and present his findings with glee.

But Ica wanted a share. So Ica followed.

When Phainon entered his house, sliding a key into the lock and quietly stepping inside, Ica was there. When Phainon placed his basket on the table and toed off his shoes, Ica was there.

And when Phainon padded down the corridor to slip into the bedroom at the end of the house, Ica was there.

Ica should not have been there.

The pale-haired man moved like moonlight, silent and caring as he came to stand beside the bed and admired the sight within.

Draped across the sheets, a vision in his dishevelled sleeping robe, Mydei slept; one hand cupped his pregnant belly out of habit, as though he were consoling their child in his sleep, while the other hand lay beside his head on the pillow.

Phainon watched him, an adoring smile on his face. Then he leaned forward to lift a lock of blond hair, pressing it to his lips and inhaling deeply.

Did Mydei smell good? Ica wondered, *did Mydei smell like food?*

Ica didn't get the opportunity to test that assumption. Ica was pretending to be a stuffed toy, standing frozen beside two plush chimaeras and a mini Mydei doll.

Soft lips moved from Mydei's hair to his forehead as Phainon kissed him sweetly, only to be disturbed as Mydei shifted out of sleep, his golden eyes blinking open drowsily, and curled his arms around Phainon's neck to pull him in for a hug.

"Oh, sorry, did I wake you?" Phainon whispered, but the wide smile on his face betrayed his lack of regret.

Blond hair fell into place as Mydei shook his head, "Missed you." To emphasise his word, he began peppering kisses all over his husband's face, light and gentle, but many.

"Dei, you're the one who sent me out running errands," came Phainon's laugh in response to the ticklish gesture, pulling away to start undressing again for bed.

"I'm sorry," Mydei's eyes were wide and apologetic, and he had a guilty expression as he spoke, returning one hand to his belly for support so he could slowly sit up. "Did you get everything?"

"Yes, dear. Two sprigs of rosemary, wheat porridge, a basket of pomegranate bark, three cups of redsoil, one cloudsheep, one hornswine and Krateros's feta. He was kinda annoyed when I knocked on his door, but when I mentioned it was for you, he gave me a whole tub."

Mydei's brow pinched. "He shouldn't have been annoyed. Why else would he get into the cheesemaking business if not to sell cheese?"

"Of course, but I'm sure he didn't expect to be selling in the middle of Curtain-fall hour."

"Hmph," The only sound in the room was the rustling of Phainon's clothes as he slipped off his sleeping robe, Mydei having gone silent in the face of his words. And then, "... love you."

Ica watched with barely concealed distaste as Phainon grinned, tumbled into the bed, and wrapped his arms around Mydei, snuggling him close and petting a hand over the curve of his stomach. It would be harder for Ica to take food if the men were still awake.

“And how’s our little sunshine?” Phainon cooed, planting a noisy kiss on the bump and mumbling sweet nothings into the fabric of Mydei’s clothes.

“Baby’s fine.” But *Mydei* clearly wasn’t, a needy whine in his voice as he tugged Phainon back up to continue kissing him. Their lips danced in a tender embrace, Mydei sinking further and further into Phainon’s hold until he was being fully supported by the hand around his waist.

Ica wanted to leave. But if Ica tried to leave, then they might get caught, and then Hyacine would put a *collar* on Ica.

A tentative hand slid across Phainon’s shoulders, over his chest, then his abs, finally reaching his crotch as Mydei rubbed insistently at the newly forming hardness.

Phainon broke away from the kiss, a thread of saliva connecting their lips as he said, “Mydei, are you sure?”

Mydei didn’t respond verbally, but his wide-blown pupils, the pout on his lips and the eager flush on his skin were enough to show his arousal, and he parted the fabric of Phainon’s robe. Ica watched with slowly mounting horror as his hand moved in slow, rhythmic motions.

Maybe Ica shouldn’t have followed their stomach.

“Sh-shit.” Desperate pants left Phainon’s lips, and he gripped Mydei’s waist tighter with one hand while the other fisted into the sheets.

When he felt a weight on his shoulder, dazed blue eyes cracked open, only to widen at the sight.

Blond hair draped over him as Mydei rested his cheek on the crook of Phainon’s neck, his clouded golden eyes staring up at him gently through wispy lashes and drinking in the lustful expression on his husband’s face. His body was warm and pliant against him, and his open-mouthed huffs caused his sleeping robe to shift, slipping open to reveal a dark, swollen nipple, dusky and perked from where it pressed against Phainon’s chest.

Phainon let out a whine, bucking his hips and pulling Mydei even closer to him as he sputtered out, “I’m gonna–”

He didn’t finish his sentence, trembling and quivering in place until Mydei withdrew his hand, now covered in sticky white.

He raised that hand to his mouth, tasting the cum with delicate, kitten-licks. “Was craving this too.”

Ica thought they were both disgustingly in love, and it would be beneficial for them to fall asleep *now* so that Ica could flee.

“Fuck– Mydei, roll onto your side.” Ica could only watch in despair as Phainon’s voice took on a more commanding tone, and he stripped off both of their robes with haste.

Mydei obeyed, cradling his swollen belly as he lay on his side and looked back eagerly over his shoulder. When Phainon caressed his hole with lubed fingers, he twitched and grabbed onto his wrist for support. “Ngh… mnh… Phai…”

Ica began to pray. Maybe Aquila would answer their call.

Meanwhile, on the bed, Phainon withdrew his fingers and curled protectively around Mydei’s shivering form to push his cock in and rock their hips together. He laced their fingers together on the swell of their unborn child, mumbling reverent words into the soft skin of his neck as he fucked into Mydei’s warmth.

If not Aquila, maybe Thanatos?

“You feel so good.. Dei, love you, love you so much,” he punctuate his words with deep thrusts, careful not to be too rough but making sure that Mydei felt it all the same.

There was no point praying to Kephale or Nikador, that was for certain.

A high-pitched mewl echoed in the room as Mydei pushed his hips back, gasping out, “Fuck, love you too–”

Ica watched as a goblet fell from the bedside table with the force of Phainon’s movements, hitting the ground with a resonant crash yet not disturbing the coupling on the bed. They were *finally* too distracted to notice their surroundings!

And with a silent trill of joy, Ica fled to safety.

In the hour after Hyacine finished up her class for expecting mothers, she liked to spend her time doing her writeups and adding to each mother’s health record; if she left that task for too much later, she may forget any small idiosyncrasies or changes to her patients’ health.

So there she was, diligently writing away, with the scratching of her pen and the occasional clinks of a spoon hitting a plate punctuating the placid quiet.

Beside her, a dispute, two beasts in conflict over the last piece of gold.

Hyacine put her pen down and shook her hand briefly to air out a cramp. Then, she was back to work.

The white beast narrowed its eyes, slowly inching towards the gold. To no avail – it was pushed back, foiled by a silver weapon.

Aunt Mel was on her fifth child, calm and confident with the whole process and displaying healthy statistics for being in her second trimester. Ms Lucia had gone through the routine stretching with ease, steady despite her huge belly in the eighth month of pregnancy, and had remembered her breathing patterns to keep calm.

The larger beast, weapon in hand, reached out to snatch the soft gold away.

Aleksandra looked a bit peaky today, Hyacine pondered, remembering the woman's pallid complexion and unhappy demeanour. It was her first pregnancy, and she was going through a rather terrible bout of morning sickness.

The white beast succeeded in stealing a piece of gold from the pile, ignoring the other's cry of outrage.

Then there was Leta, who had smiled and waved at her husband when he dropped her off for the class, only to turn around with a frown and complain about his snoring keeping her up. Io, her close confidant over a shared annoyance with their significant others, had ushered her in and shared with her a portion of honey cakes from the basket she had provided.

And of course, Mydei–

CLINK!

Two sets of eyes looked up at her sheepishly, Mydei's silver spoon hitting the bottom of the plate too hard as he cornered off the last bite of golden honeycakes from Ica's gluttonous gaze. He sat still for a moment, like a chimaera caught slacking off of work, before lifting the spoon to his mouth and swallowing the sweet treat.

Then Mydei placed his spoon down, and announced, "My husband has forgotten me."

"I'm sure he hasn't forgotten you–"

"My husband has forgotten me," Mydei repeated, propping his folded arms on his belly and leaning back against the kline he was sprawled across, "and he's gone on to pursue a more soft-spoken person with a slighter figure."

"...Right. That's just not true is it? Phainon can't go through one conversation without talking about your body." Hyacine was feeling a strange sense of deja vu to the time she had caught Mydei drunk in the medical bay. Here she was again, consoling Mydei that *no*, Phainon hadn't lost interest in him and *yes*, Phainon would fight a titan for him.

Just because he was late in picking Mydei up after the end of Hyacine's maternity class, it didn't mean that Mydei had been *forgotten*, much less that Phainon was no longer interested in him or his body.

"My earlier body. Before I blew up like a baby seal."

"What. Mydei, you 'blew up' because you got pregnant."

“So you agree?” Hyacine really had to stop getting into these situations. The last time Mydei had assumed her agreement with one of his obscure ideas, she ended up failing to realise as he went through a whole trimester of pregnancy. “My husband is a terrible, *terrible* man who would leave his pregnant wife for a twink.”

“Mydei, what are you talking about.” Hyacine didn’t know what a twink was, she didn’t know why Mydei thought Phainon would prefer them over him, and she didn’t know why she hadn’t yet quit her job to pursue a hermit’s life in the mountains.

Actually no, on second thought, she wouldn’t enjoy the life of a hermit. She loved people too much.

“The Trailblazer taught me that word,” Mydei sniffed, “It means a young man with a small build.”

Maybe she didn’t love people *that* much.

“Right. What makes you think your husband would prefer a… *twink* over you?” It was Hyacine’s firm opinion that Phainon’s ideal type was someone who could be his equal, in both body and spirit, so her voice was full of disbelief.

That got him thinking, and Hyacine watched as he rested his head on one of his hands in thought, stroking the curve of his stomach rhythmically. “Easier to push around?”

“But you let Phainon push you around anyway,” Hyacine argued, referencing the numerous times she had seen Mydei let his husband herd him around like he was the charge of a particularly insistent sheepdog, “and besides, he's crazy about you. Haven't you seen the number of interviews and articles he's done just to talk about you? He's broadcasting your relationship even *beyond* Amphoreus.”

“It doesn't matter. He's not here right now.” He shifted in place, and his brows furrowed in distress. “Ever since I felt the baby quickening, he’s been taking on more work,” Mydei shrank in on himself, wrapping an arm around his belly as if to console his baby, even though it looked more like he was consoling himself. “Is he starting to feel the pressure? Does he want to leave me?”

Hyacine stood up abruptly to make her way over to him. She held a lot of distaste for their public shows of affection, it was true, but she would never, *never* sit idle and watch one of them in such distress.

And as she tried to soothe Mydei, hugging him close and mumbling words to refute his insecurities, the man of the hour appeared at the door.

“How are my darlings?” Phainon chirped, making a beeline to hold Mydei with a sunny grin on his face, while completely failing to acknowledge the person keeping his tears at bay.

Oh hi, Hyacine, how have you been, Hyacine? My day was great, Hyacine, thank you for looking after Mydei for me, Hyacine.

Mydei turned his head with a petulant noise, refusing to make eye contact with the other man. “One of us is fine.” There was a pout on his lips, and Hyacine had been around the couple enough times to know that Phainon's usual solution to resolving that expression was by kissing Mydei silly.

No, thank you, she thought, moving aside to clear up the mats and paraphernalia dotted around the floor from the maternity class.

Phainon’s cajoling voice wafted through the room as he pawed Mydei’s shoulder like an excited puppy. “Aw, Mydei, did you miss me? I'm sorry, honey, I didn't mean to take so long.”

“Excuse me,” Hyacine pushed past to give Ica the medical records that needed returning to her office.

“Oh, hey, Hyacine.” Phainon greeted, then he turned back to Mydei and began petting his hair like he was a rather frazzled cat, “I'll make it up to you. I bought you some snacks.”

At that, golden eyes snapped to attention, lighting up at the sight of a box of pomegranate cakes and nutty kataifi rolls emerging from Phainon’s coat. Mydei was not the only one to notice – Ica’s beady eyes also followed the box, and the unicorn approached silently to grab a bite.

Hyacine’s jaw dropped as the Last Prince of Kremnos, Mydeimos the Undying, *hissed* at the chubby unicorn, guarding his box of treats with vicious certainty.

There was a first for everything it seemed. Hyacine turned back to her work.

Phainon paid them no mind, kneeling at Mydei’s feet to place a hand on his belly and talk to the baby while their mother nibbled at a pastry. “Hello, sunshine,” He crooned, “Papa’s here. Have you been good to your mama?”

There was an annoyed, “Hmph.”

“Eh? What's wrong, my love, why are you upset?”

Mydei stared at him for a second, anger burning in his eyes, before abruptly saying, “Fight me.”

“What?!” Phainon’s incredulous voice rang out, followed by a hesitant laugh and a timid, “don't joke like that, sweetheart.”

“I'm not joking,” Mydei snapped, and the sound of a smack told Hyacine that he had batted away the hand reaching to cup his face, fixing the man before him with a glare.

“Dei, we've talked about this, we have to be careful about the baby–”

They both gasped, a shrill intake of air that usually followed exclamations of horror, potentially signifying something was wrong and prompting Hyacine to spin around quickly with her hands already raised for action. “What? What is it?”

A moment of silence. And another.

Then–

A deluge of tears burst forth, Phainon bawling into Mydei's lap as his hands desperately encircled his baby bump. Mydei's reaction was more subdued, but no less in wonder, his pupils blown wide and his lips parted in surprise as he stared down at where his hand was placed on his stomach.

"Stop blubbering, Phainon. What happened?" Hyacine was going to rip her hair out, rife with worry at what could have caused such a severe reaction in the two men.

Phainon lifted his head, a mess of tears on his face as he let out an unintelligible noise.

"I understood none of that." Hyacine turned to the blond, "Mydei?"

In a soft voice, with his earlier annoyance dissipated, Mydei said, "Baby kicked. Heh, she's willing to fight on my behalf."

Oh.

It was as though the atmosphere in the room had shifted into something awe-inspiring, something strong, something beautiful, as Hyacine watched the stirrings of new life bring such emotion in the expecting parents.

It was always a miraculous thing, seeing how people reacted to their baby's kicking in the womb, but somehow it felt *different*, knowing that the baby in question was the child of two of Hyacine's dearest friends.

Then Mydei's words caught up to her. "She? You think they'll be a girl?"

"Just a hunch," His words were followed by a little smile, excited and proud for the child they would soon meet.

"Phainon, what do you think?"

"I– I don't care–" Phainon was still snivelling into Mydei's clothes, unwilling to lift himself away from the baby as he stuttered out, "as long as– healthy, gotta be healthy–"

"HKS, quit flooding Hyacine's clinic." An exasperated huff, followed by a gentle pinch of his cheek as Mydei cupped his face, "Take me home."

A loyal puppy as ever, Hyacine watched as Phainon supported Mydei by the waist, tugging him to his feet whilst sobbing uncontrollably, "Love you, Dei, love you and our baby so, *so much*." And they took a few shaky steps out of the clinic, Phainon frantically holding onto the swell of Mydei's stomach and causing both of them to walk lopsidedly. Mydei let out a quiet mumble.

Even through his tears, Phainon was eager to listen, sniffling loudly and stopping in his tracks to meet golden eyes. "Huh? What was that?"

“... I said you don't pick me up as much anymore. Am I too heavy?”

Hyacine could see the exact moment when those words struck Phainon’s soul – he wailed aloud like Ica when they were hungry, sweeping Mydei into a familiar princess carry while being careful not to jostle him too much.

“Don't ever say that! You're light as a feather to me,” he insisted, then he planted a wet kiss on Mydei’s temple and marched the two of them out of the clinic with the tears still streaming down his face.

“Aquila above,” Hyacine muttered, reaching out to comfort Ica, who was still offended after having been denied a snack, “just how are those two going to be like as parents?”

Mydei’s intense craving for food died down between the end of his second trimester and the start of his third, getting replaced by a craving for his husband; thankfully, Hyacine hadn’t witnessed any evidence of that, only learning of it due to Aglaea’s annoyance when she received yet another complaint from a citizen catching the couple.

Okhema’s citizens were generally well-meaning when it came to Mydei’s pregnancy, cooing over his rounded belly and wishing him well as he strolled through the streets, but some were more… *judgmental* than most.

It was on a grocery trip that Hyacine first caught sight of that judgment, accompanying Phainon and Mydei because the latter had burst into tears and cried when he sat down to consider the impact he had caused by denying Ica snacks.

Now they were in the market, Mydei insistent on buying groceries to make a dessert for Ica and Hyacine.

“What about this? Ica, do you like peaches?”

Ica would quite literally eat the peaches, the seed, the basket, the awning, the vendor – there was no need to question if they liked something or not.

“Doot-doot!” Was Ica’s cheerful reply, and the peaches went inside the already overflowing basket.

Phainon was on basket-carrying duty, yet he kept his distance from Ica, smiling as he tentatively called out, “Heh, Mydei, be careful, alright? If Ica gets too hungry, they might eat you!”

Hyacine could tell that Mydei thought his words were a joke, his answering scoff being more than clear, but Phainon was telling the truth – once, many years ago, when Hyacine had been too swamped with her medical studies to feed Ica, it had happened.

Ica went hunting.

No one in the Grove talked about it, but from that day onwards, everyone knew to always be wary of the little white unicorn.

“Oh my, Lord Mydei, don't you look absolutely radiant!” A gaggle of tittering gossips interrupted Hyacine's reflections, led by a woman with gaudy makeup and an overdramatic hairdo, and surrounded them with the stifling smell of too much perfume and drowned hopes for their futures.

Mydei greeted the woman at the front politely with a nod and an, “Ah, Miss Cassondra.” But, he looked uncomfortable as he spoke, and Hyacine inched closer to him to stand by his side. Just where had Phainon gone?

The horde started to chatter. “Lucius, doesn't he look absolutely wonderful?” A simpering voice, followed by a man’s, “certainly, why, most pregnant people I've seen look absolutely drained,” only to be shut down by a snippy, “ah, but it's alright, their babies come out perfectly healthy – it's as if they take the mother’s beauty in exchange for health!”

Mydei’s brow furrowed, and Hyacine bristled at those words: *just what were they trying to imply?*

Describing a mother’s beauty as a marker for the health of the baby was a concept that held no basis in any medical knowledge and would only serve to stress Mydei out. Yet perhaps that may have been their final goal, as Hyacine was slowly realising.

After all, some of these gossips held outdated beliefs, either a distaste for the Kremnoans or a general dislike for the Chrysos heirs as symbols of Okhema. Were Mydei to display any form of weakness, they could easily twist that to showcase his unsuitability to lead Okhema in her new age.

All of a sudden, a swarm of hands were reaching out to Mydei’s belly in the hopes of touching, followed by overlapping voices that culminated in a shrill, “Shall we check if the baby wants to talk to us yet? Their mother is so busy, they're practically going to be raised by us, I imagine!”

Those words elicited a violent flinch from Mydei and his face paled – the latter end of his pregnancy had dulled his reflexes slightly, and there was nowhere to escape.

Hyacine summoned Ica to her side, about to instruct them to barge through the crowd, reputations be damned, until a firm arm around Mydei’s midriff pulled him aside.

“Come now, everyone, please don't try to touch Mydei like that, he's clearly uncomfortable.” Phainon’s words were polite and he had his usual placating smile stretched across his lips, but his eyes were cold, watching the crowd warily from where he had placed himself between Mydei and their greedy hands.

“Oh no, Lord Phainon, we would never mean for that! It's just the hormones, I imagine, they're always so terrible on the mind,” said a man, raising his hands up in a peaceful gesture.

But Hyacine had seen that man in the clinic before, simpering and sugary, only to be warned by her assistant that he was nothing but a ruthless gossipmonger who disguised his malice with kind words.

“No.” Phainon wasn’t smiling anymore. “It's not *hormones,* can't you see you're bothering my husband with your words?”

He continued, not letting the crowd’s dithering distract him. “Our baby will be healthy and strong, you don't need to concern yourself with that. And also, even if Mydei *is* busy in the future, you're mistaken to think that our children would end up neglected – he and I are *more than capable* of making sacrifices for their joy.”

And with those words, he steered Mydei away, not sparing them another glance. With a broad grin on her face, Hyacine followed.

That was a brilliant display, seeing the man shift from Mydei’s besotted husband, Phainon, to the championed Deliverer of Okhema, remaining calm in the face of the snakes. As they traversed through the market, Hyacine *not* struggling to keep up for once as Phainon was setting a lighter pace to support Mydei, she found herself looking up at the men’s expressions.

Mydei appeared less stunned, but still docile, a light wash of pink on his face and a strange mix of emotion in his eyes as he snuck glances at his husband. Phainon, on the other hand, was furious, white-hot rage simmering in his eyes as he clenched his jaw.

No one spoke, tentative to break the stony silence as they moved through the streets. It was only until they were a reasonable distance away, at the crossroads leading to either the Marmoreal Palace or the city’s residential zone, that Mydei finally let out a laugh.

“... *children*?” He teased, reaching a hand to stroke Phainon’s cheek and smiling as the ice in his eyes melted, and his face heated up.

Hyacine’s brows pinched in disbelief – not even half a quint after such a moment of stress, and they were already back to their nonsense. But, when she considered it, perhaps Mydei was trying to redirect the conversation for their own good.

Phainon rubbed the back of his neck, his eyes flitting around. “Well… you know… what if our first baby gets lonely…” Hyacine stopped and bent down to fix her shoe, the buckle having loosened on their way out, “we don't want them growing up feeling left out… and then also…” Their voices faded as they disappeared down the route to their home, becoming quieter and quieter until they could no longer be heard.

Unbelievable. They had just… continued walking. Without Hyacine.

Hyacine, who had her arms laden with *their* groceries. She turned to look at Ica beside her, beady eyed and shaking as they stared hungrily at the basket of food. “Ica, could you drop these off at their house?” Seeing how hesitant the unicorn was to go, she added, “you can have some as a payment, but I will be checking if they received the rest!”

They had developed a new transport system for goods, sending Ica to make deliveries for the Twilight Courtyard when the distance was too long or inconvenient for Hyacine to travel herself. Of course, to make sure recipients actually received their order, they had to provide Ica with a gratitude token which they had either been given by Hyacine earlier in the day, or just had lying around.

Otherwise Ica may eat their order, and no one would ever know.

“Doot… doot,” Ica responded to Hyacine in a strangely despairing tone, as though they were afraid to visit Phainon and Mydei. Eh, she was probably mistaken.

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Ica knew exactly why they had sped off to return home and left Hyacine in the dust to fix her shoe with a bewildered look. Ica had seen the desire in Mydei’s eyes as they left the market, passionate and hungry as he watched Phainon’s anger on his behalf.

Hopefully, if Ica made it to their home fast enough, they could deliver the groceries, collect the token and avoid having to see the two men… *together*.

Hope was not on Ica’s side.

As Ica floated down the hallway, carrying the basket like a shield, they saw the bedroom door wide open. And in the bedroom–

“Ah… uhm… Dei, you feel so good–” Phainon’s mellow moans echoed throughout the house, interspersed with the steady sounds of skin meeting skin as the two men made love on their bed.

Mydei was straddling his husband’s hips, the muscles in his thighs shifting as he pushed himself up and down. There was an expression of clear adoration on his face as he looked down at Phainon, slowing down his movements to catch his breath.

“My husband loves me so much,” he leaned down to kiss him, hindered slightly by his swollen stomach, “you were so dashing today, defending me like that.”

Phainon’s hands trailed down Mydei’s figure, caressing his darkened areolas before tracing down to his belly, and he stroked the curve, frowning as he mumbled out, “Didn't like how they were talking about you.”

Ica didn’t like how they were talking, full stop. Could someone please just notice them floating in the doorway with the basket so they could leave.

Mydei smiled and cupped his hand around Phainon’s cheek. “They're notorious gossips, they talk to everyone like that.”

He received no further response to his words, only a muted grumble as Phainon switched his attention to tightening his hold on Mydei's hips and using his biceps to aid him in moving. Maybe if Ica were a fan of such things, like Castorice, they would have found it romantic how the strain on Mydei's thighs reduced, being placed on Phainon's arms instead.

But Ica did not believe in romance. Ica believed in food.

There was a delighted cry as Mydei realised what Phainon was doing, and he curled forward once more to claim his lips in a loving kiss. They lost themselves in each other's taste for so long that Phainon rolled them over, until they were both cuddling on their sides as they pressed their hips together as close as they could despite the baby bump in the middle.

Belatedly, Ica considered making a noise, something to signify that they were unfortunately being subjected to the sight.

"You're so perfect… Dei, honey…" A hand slid down to Mydei's thigh, grasping the plush softness as Phainon hiked it higher over his hip to push deeper inside, resulting in a pleased whine from the blond.

"Gurgh– 's many as you want, we can have as many babies as you want–!" He threw his head back as he mewled, reaching a shaky hand up to pinch and tug at one of his full breasts as though soothing a dull ache.

Phainon batted his hand away to replace it with his mouth in a practised motion, and a faint milky scent filled the air as white dribbled from both of Mydei's puffy nipples, eagerly swallowed up by the man suckling on his breast.

That was it, Ica had had enough. "Brrrt!"

The desperate motions on the bed stopped, both men freezing at the sound of the unicorn in the room. Ica heard Mydei whisper in a hoarse voice, confused as he said, "Is that– is that *Ica*?"

Inky eyes met blue as Phainon sat up to see Ica watching them with a thousand-yard stare.

"Oh, Ica's got our groceries," he noted upon seeing the basket, licking a drop of milk off his lip and following with a smile. "Thanks buddy!"

Ica would prefer if Phainon didn't call them buddy while balls-deep in his wife. Ica did not want to be Phainon's *buddy*. Not if Phainon believed that mere words of gratitude were enough, going back to his earlier task of pleasuring Mydei with vigour while leaving Ica floating there in silence.

When Phainon pulled back from Mydei's chest to switch to his other breast, he noticed Ica. "You're still here?"

"The token, give Ica the token."

Thank Aquila for Mydei! The man had his forearm draped across his eyes, panting quietly while Phainon let out a noise of assent and pulled out of him to go hunting through the

bedside drawers for a token.

And finally, *finally*, Ica was passed a little round piece of metal, free to leave at last.

(“How long was Ica there for?”

“Hmm, dunno. It's ok, they probably just thought we were cuddling or something.”

“...Sure.”

“Ah, don't worry about it honey. Now, where were we?”)

“Alright, Ica, are you ready?”

Hyacine could have sworn she saw them shake their head in refusal, refusing to set foot (float?) on the porch of the house they were conducting a home visit to. Thankfully, it was a simple procedure and all Hyacine had to do was take note of a few vitals, share some necessary information, and then head out.

“Come on, I don’t want to be here either. They’re shameless enough in public, Aquila knows what they get up to at home,” she grumbled, “but Mydei’s so close to labour, we have to visit.”

It was the eighth month of pregnancy, and so there was little to do now but prepare for the birth and instruct Mydei on the proper breathing exercises to help him through delivery. Although, honestly, part of Hyacine believed Mydei would treat childbirth like any other battle and power through it with ease, so she was less worried.

A moment after she knocked, yanking Ica forward before they could try to flee, the door swung open to reveal Phainon, his hair rumpled and a yawn escaping his mouth.

“Hyacine! And Ica,” Phainon looked a little sheepish when he saw Ica’s distraught face, “you guys are early.”

“Did we interrupt you?” Hyacine asked, too tired to care about shame in the third quint of Entry hour. Besides, this late into the pregnancy, she had learnt far too many things about her friends’ private lives to feel any embarrassment, taking account of them with a clinical understanding.

Her words only evoked a hearty laugh, and Phainon ushered them in.

The house was steadily getting baby-proofed, all the sharp weapons and paraphernalia locked away in the cabinets. Phainon’s collections of antiques were placed on elevated surfaces, well out of the way of grabby little hands, and Hyacine could see a small play area being formed in the corner of the main room with a half-built crib sitting in the middle of the soft mats.

Upon noticing her gaze fixed on the crib, Phianon rubbed the back of his neck sheepishly, “Ah, I was in the middle of building it when you guys knocked.”

Hyacine’s eyes softened as she properly took in his appearance. The man looked excited, and yet there was no mistaking the deep bags under his eyes – he was evidently looking forward to the baby’s arrival, but first-time nerves affected everyone in these situations.

Still, the scene was domestic and sweet. Phainon deserved this.

“Dei’s still asleep. Actually, he’s been sleeping a lot more lately, is that normal?” He asked, leading them down the corridor. Ica shivered.

Hyacine nodded. “It’s common in the third trimester, his body’s using a lot more energy to support the baby.”

Then they were in the bedroom, and if Hyacine thought that the main room of the house looked domestic, then the bedroom was a proper lion’s den, cosy and safe. It was likely due to the nesting instincts, both parents preparing the perfect space to raise their baby.

There was another crib in the corner, carved from oak and shaped so that there was a rocking mechanism if one were to push it. If Hyacine wasn’t mistaken, that must have been a gift from Krateros – with the dissolution of the Kremnoan monarchy, she had seen the man expanding into newer fields such as cheesemaking, gardening and carpentry.

And in the centre of the bed, sprawled on the sheets as he slumbered, was Mydei, blond hair draped across his prone form as he lay on his side, curled around his belly. His sleeping clothes were askew in sleep, and Hyacine could see a few stains on the chest area. Good thing she brought extra bandages.

Hyacine began setting her stuff up on a rocking chair in the room as Phainon made his way over to the bed, leaning down to press a kiss to Mydei’s cheek and murmuring, “Honey, Hyacine’s here.”

He could have woken him up in a less sappy way. He could have done this without forcing Hyacine and Ica to see.

“Mrm?” Like an affectionate cat, Mydei made a tired little noise as his golden eyes blinked open drowsily. Hyacine held back a squeal – he was rather cute.

He stretched out a tattooed arm and wrapped it around the nape of Phainon's neck, pulling him forward to nuzzle into his cheek. And then, all of a sudden, the two men were kissing in a slow, languid motion.

That was not rather cute.

They only broke apart when Ica plopped down rather loudly on the dresser, situating themselves in between the stuffed chimaeras and a mini doll of Mydei like they had been there before. Odd.

“Hey there, Mydei,” Hyacine greeted, keeping her voice quiet, “how are you feeling?”

A slow blink. “Sleepy,” followed by a big yawn while he sat up, using Phainon’s arm for support.

Hyacine wondered whether their child would have the same feline mannerisms as Mydei – his wide yawns, leisurely blinks, and his love for napping. Or maybe, they might take after Phainon, all joyful and extroverted like a happy puppy.

Well, perhaps no longer a puppy – as the years passed and Phainon became stronger and his presence more solid, though no less benevolent, he was akin to a big, friendly dog. Hyacine could almost see a tail wagging behind him as the man left the room, hurrying away in search of something.

She turned her attention back to Mydei. “Let me take your temperature and your health markers first.” She said, and the blond nodded as he leaned back against the pillows.

Nearing the end of his eighth month, Hyacine could see that the baby had already dropped down into Mydei’s pelvis, an evident shift in position for the bump as he had earlier been carrying high.

Moreover, the strain on his hips and back would have increased, explaining his fatigue and hesitation to move around much; the baby was big, no doubt, and Mydei’s ankles looked painfully swollen.

Yet despite it all, the man still looked radiant, as though nothing could make him happier than he already was.

It was when Hyacine was scribbling down her final notes from the physical examination – the milk was coming in as normal, if not slightly overproduced, a healthy sign – that Phainon returned to the bedroom with a warmed bowl of oil.

Mydei brightened at the sight.

Curiously, Hyacine watched as Phainon put the bowl down on the bedside table, only pausing to ask, “He doesn’t need to move around any more, right, Hyacine?”

“Huh? Oh, yes.”

With her affirmation, he knelt on the bed, lifting Mydei’s shirt to expose the swell of his belly. For a moment, he stared, a burst of emotion in his eyes.

Then he dipped his hands in the heated oil, and began massaging it into the stretch of skin, humming like he was just doing another daily chore.

Mydei didn't say anything, looking expectantly at Hyacine for her next questions. Huh, for once, Hyacine wasn't the one not being acknowledged in the room.

Beside her, Ica fluttered closer to the bowl of oil and sniffed, only to recoil with a spit. It must have been olive oil. Ica didn't like olive oil.

The rest of the examination was conducted solely through questions, so it was easy for Hyacine to settle into the tranquillity of the room and ask about Mydei's mental state, habits and other necessary things. Mydei was surprisingly good with the pregnancy, not having any major concerns or issues – it seemed he was a natural mother.

Hyacine finished her questions at the same time as Phainon finished rubbing Mydei's baby bump, and the pale-haired man stood up with a flourish after wiping his hands on a towel.

“Hyacine, stay for tea?”

It wasn't as though she had anywhere else to be for a while, she could spare a quint or two. “If you don’t mind,” and Phainon shuffled away again, taking the bowl of oil with him, to Ica's relief.

In any case, this was going to be one of the last few moments Hyacine could spend with the men before they became swamped with the ordeal of parenting. She wanted to savour it while it lasted, grinning as she spoke to Mydei. “Are you excited? Only a few more weeks now.”

Mydei nodded assuredly, only to follow up with a slow, “But, I suppose I will miss being doted on like this.”

That was an absolutely ridiculous thing to miss. All he had to do was ask, and Hyacine knew that Phainon would gladly offer him the world. If there was a puddle on the ground, he would sweep Mydei off his feet so he didn't have to muddy his shoes – that much they already knew – and if he couldn't lift Mydei up, for whatever reason, he might strip off his elegant white coat and lay it across the ground to make a carpet for Mydei to cross.

Phainon returned once more, this time carrying a tray laden with a tea set and a plate of Mydei's favourite snacks, along with the reheated bowl of oil. When he had passed Mydei and Hyacine their tea and placed the tray to the side, he sat on the bed beside the blond’s feet.

He lifted Mydei's swollen ankles onto his lap, and with his oiled hands, began to rub and massage the tender flesh with gentle motions, caressing the skin there with so much *love* in his eyes that Hyacine felt annoyed.

Why were they making her chew on dog food this early in the day? It paired terribly with the taste of tea.

When Phainon was dragged away on an expedition to Tretos by Professor Anaxa, along with strangely enough, *Ica*, Lady Tribbie organised a picnic to keep Mydei company for the day.

“It’ll be like a girls night!” She had chirped. No one wanted to tell her that with Mydei involved, it was no longer a *‘girls* night’, and since the picnic would take place during the day, it wasn’t really a ‘girls *night’* either.

Regardless of the arrangement, there they were, gathered in a circle in the Garden of Life with chimaeras lounging around them as they enjoyed each other's company, along with the snacks that Mydei had taught Castorice to make as his pregnancy made him less and less able to stand in the kitchen for long to cook.

Despite waking up early that day to see Phainon off, Mydei had been less drowsy and more active, and he looked content sitting in the grass while absently holding his swollen belly.

Awash in the gold rays of the day, he made a gorgeous sight. Hyacine almost felt bad for Phainon, missing such a view because he was forced to go gallivanting with Anaxa in the search for… something or other. Honestly, even *she* didn't know.

“Dei, would you like to do gifts now?” Trianne bounced up from where she was sunbathing beside Hyacine in a little puppy pile with Tribbie and Trinnon. At her words, all three of them trotted over to Mydei, breaking him out of the lazy haze he had fallen into.

Fogginess was common during Mydei’s pregnancy, and Hyacine had often found him staring into space while Phainon flitted around him like an overexcited dove. However, it was easy to bring him back to attention, and he gave a small smile as he said, “Sure, I’d like that.”

Tribbie looked to Aglaea expectantly.

Then, a Garmentmaker floated into view, carrying a hamper filled to the brim with gifts: a few were wrapped, neatly packed in pinks and blues and lilacs, whereas some had pretty gold ribbons tied around them to elevate the original packaging; Hyacine could see big gifts and small, some for the baby and some for the parents.

Mydei’s lips had parted in surprise. “So many?”

He was right in that regard, for the basket was so stuffed that it might have burst at the seams if not for the Garmentmaker holding it together with some thread. But it wasn't a surprise, to Hyacine at least, that the people of Okhema had so much love for the expecting Chrysos heirs.

Excluding the people that were *close* to Mydei and Phainon, such as Mydei's teacher or even just the other Chrysos heirs, they were beloved by many in the city.

Phainon could always be found doing odd jobs around the city, treated like a reliable son in the way many asked him to fix their roofs, help them carry their heavy supplies, or even just have an intellectual conversation. Similarly, Mydei was always playing with the city's children or being spoiled by the multitude of business owners, eager to get his opinion on the taste of their new food.

Their child would no doubt be the darling of the city – of this much Hyacine was certain.

“Heh, I’ll go first, mine’s at the top!” Tribbie called out, reaching into the hamper to pull out a box wrapped in red paper and passing it to Mydei.

He peeled off the paper, golden eyes widening at the sight of a music box, engraved with chimaeras and flowers. “It’s beautiful.” His voice was awed as he undid the clasp holding it shut, and revealed the interior.

Two mini figurines, one red and one blue, were locked in battle; as Mydei twisted the dial on the side to start the peaceful chimes of song, the two figures started to fight, dancing across the surface of the box in a light-hearted spar.

“I hope your baby likes it, we worked hard on carving the statues of you and Snowy. Mr Krateros let us use his workshop!”

She didn't know about the baby, but Hyacine could tell that *Mydei* certainly loved the box.

Next in the basket was a parcel of books, quietly handed over by a nervous Trinnon. Hyacine couldn't see all of them from where she was sat, but there were titles such as ‘How to survive a new baby’ and ‘Baby chimaeras feed off their parents’ joy’ – they were all clearly aimed at easing the stress of looking after an infant.

“Looking after yourself when you have a newborn is hard so…” Her words trailed off as she fidgeted on the spot, only to be calmed by Mydei pulling her in for a grateful hug.

Trianne sprang up when it was her turn, rocking on the balls of her feet excitedly as she watched Mydei unwrap a set of training weapons, crafted to be identical to Mydei's gauntlets and Phainon’s Dawnmaker.

“Well?” she said, her hands on her hips as she grinned toothily at the blond, “what do you think? Cool, right? Chartonus helped us make these as accurate as possible!”

“It’s better than making the baby play with metal, that’s for sure. Phainon will like these too, I think, he says he wants to teach the baby the sword and defeat me.”

Hyacine held back a giggle. Mydei looked serious as he spoke, but all she could think of was Phainon commanding an army of tiny babies to attack their mother, only to be vanquished by an endearing quirk of an eyebrow, and fall to the floor.

After Trianne was Aglaea, lifting out a pile of clothes laced together with her signature gold thread. As she laid them out, showcasing each piece individually, Hyacine couldn't help but squeal.

There were the most *adorable* of baby clothes, cosy onesies and bonnets and swaddling robes in different rotations of patterns: chimaeras, dromases, even Ica. Besides them, Aglaea had also made a set of maternity robes, designed to support Mydei in his postpartum recovery without overheating his body.

“Lady Aglaea…” Mydei looked speechless, his jaw properly dropped at the sight.

Aglaea shook off his astonishment with a smile. “If you *ever* need anything, we’re here for you.”

When Phainon had first made his way to Okhema, he was a rugged thing, young and inexperienced in the ways of a large city. Yet Hyacine had watched as Aglaea took him under her wing, dressing him in fine robes, teaching him the art of leadership and treating him to the city's delicacies; she may have been cursed to lose her humanity as the years went on, but there was no doubt that Phainon was as dear to her as a son.

She must be feeling like a proud parent, Hyacine mused, watching as the woman's hands trembled slightly as she handled the set of tiny clothes.

Castorice handed over a hand-knitted blanket, decorated with images of cats and dogs playing in a field of golden wheat and red flowers. It was a beautiful thing, clearly shown to have taken time and effort, and Hyacine smiled as Mydei's eyes became watery when he accepted it.

He couldn't hug her in his condition, not wanting to put the baby at risk even if his immortal body might provide some protection, so he hugged the blanket instead, holding it close as he valiantly held back tears.

For such a scary man, Mydei looked cute like this, heavy with his unborn baby and showered in soft presents, a painfully domestic sight.

Hyacine looked into the basket and pulled out the last few gifts. “Ah, these ones are from Professor Anaxa and Ica, and… Krateros, I think.”

Anaxa had sent a pack of the Grove's signature coffee, not caring to wrap it, but writing a note on the side that simply said, *‘Infants are a handful. Take care.*’ Everyone pretended not to notice as Aglaea scoffed when Mydei read the note aloud, even if the coffee was tied in a familiar thread of gold.

From Krateros, a set of carved wooden warriors and a flagon of freshly pressed pomegranate juice – it seemed he had found a new hobby in juice making.

As for Ica… they had sent a heavy package, clumsily wrapped in white paper and the word ‘ICA’ scrawled on it in black ink. Hyacine stared at it blankly.

What. Ica didn’t have thumbs. How did Ica wrap this, and write their name on it as well.

Mydei didn’t seem to have the same questions, opening the package to reveal a platter of preserved fruits and candies, which Hyacine could recognise as being from Ica’s special stash. How sweet!

“The last one’s mine,” Hyacine pulled out the final gift. She was a little nervous as she spoke, passing the present to Mydei, “it’s probably not as useful as the other gifts but–”

“I'll cherish it.” There was a look of wide-eyed determination on Mydei’s face, resolute in his show of appreciation for Hyacine’s gift. Then, he unwrapped it, revealing to the group what Hyacine had made.

If there was anything she had learned in her years of being a physician, it was that the trick to lulling babies to sleep was either by singing to them softly, patting them rhymicallly, or showing them something repetitive to calm them down.

So, in the infrequent breaks she had between patients, Hyacine had made a mobile.

Attached to a curved glass ceiling, decorated with stars and constellations of the sky, were eight long threads, and on six of those threads were little trinkets: a golden butterfly, a chubby unicorn, a miniature dromas, a mischievous grey cat, a lilac dragon and a cluster of white flowers.

And above them, on the remaining two threads, were an intertwined set of chimaeras, ginger and white like the ones familiar to the Garden of Life, nuzzling each other lovingly with their tails interlinked.

Hyacine had taken Tribbie's help to make a rotating mechanism, and when she switched it on in demonstration, the mobile began to spin slowly, glowing faintly as the trinkets and chimaeras waltzed under the domed sky.

Mydei let out a shaky breath, raising his fingers to run them through the threads of the mobile, and murmuring, "Hyacine–"

Then his face *twisted*.

"Ngh–" Mydei curled in over his stomach, grasping at it in distress as he let out a pained groan, the gifts discarded to the side.

Castorice started forward, only to hold herself back at the last second; everyone else, however, tried to crowd around him with worry evident on their faces. But Hyacine, well-versed in remaining calm under pressure and immediately switching into physician mode, kept them back.

"Mydei?" She asked, her voice clear and firm, "What's wrong? Is it the baby?"

He jerked his head in a nod.

Hyacine took his hands in hers, allowing him to clutch at them instead of potentially hurting himself by pressing on his belly. "What does it feel like?"

"Like– like a really bad muscle cramp–" He gritted out, his brows furrowed, and his eyes squeezed shut.

"Ok, that's probably a contraction." It wasn't uncommon to have contractions this close to Mydei's due date, but it could be the sign of his labour starting. "Do you remember your breathing exercises? Can you do them for me?"

Steadily, Mydei did as he was told – two short breaths followed by one deep exhale – but his pain didn't seem to alleviate.

"Is this an isolated contraction?"

“No… I've had… a few–”

“Mydei, you should have told me!” Hyacine chided, but she didn’t want to stress Mydei out by telling him off more. “When was your last one?”

“Dunno… just now,” He slurred out, swaying a little from where he was sitting. “But you said… you said– *two more weeks*–”

If Mydei was having frequent contractions, then it was clear – he was in labour. Hyacine turned to the others hovering anxiously over them, her gaze focused on Aglaea. “Lady Aglaea, could you please contact Phainon?”

Thankfully, she had sent one of her nymphs alongside the man, and so it wouldn’t be too difficult for her to let him know that his baby was on the way.

“Here, I’ll open a Century Gate,” Trinnon looked slightly queasy as she did so, her face pallid at the sight of Mydei in such evident pain, yet her hands stable as she went through the motions.

Along with Tribbie and Trianne, Hyacine helped Mydei to his feet, supporting his shaky form as he winced through his contractions. And then all of a sudden, Hyacine heard a wet noise, and looked down to see the bottom of Mydei's clothes damp.

His water had broken.

“Wh-what?” He clutched at his belly, sweat slipping down his face as he panted out a panicked groan. “Hyacine, it’s *too early*!”

The terror was obvious on his agonised face, his breathing erratic and the hand cradling his belly shaking. The other hand, wrapped around Hyacine's shoulder, was steady, as though her firm grip was enough to soothe him.

She gave him a reassuring smile as she led him through the Gate, saying, “No, it’s alright. Two weeks isn’t enough to be premature, your baby will be fine, I promise.”

“The baby is just excited to see you!” Trianne chirped, and perhaps it was the knowledge that the Tribios triplets were bearers of prophecies, or perhaps it was simply the assured confidence with which she spoke, but Mydei took a deep breath, blinked a few times, and then he was back to his normal calm.

The actual birthing itself was nothing out of the ordinary; despite Mydei's *different* parts, his body seemed to have reorganised itself to deliver the baby, and once his initial concerns had dissipated, Mydei’s indomitable perseverance returned.

(There *was* one moment, when they had him safely on one of the medical bay’s klines, Tribbie feeding him ice chips while Hyacine checked his dilation, that he panicked, reaching out to hold onto Hyacine's hand.

“Hyacine,” Mydei had desperately asked, “Hyacine, if something happens to me–”

Hyacine had cut his words off, “Nothing’s going to happen to you Mydei, I promise –”

“If something happens, will you look after my baby?”

She had been stunned. Her role had gone from being followed around Okhema and forced to witness their egregious amounts of affection, to being asked to look after their child in a worst case scenario. “You…”

“I trust you… and–” He had groaned, and a quick check showed that he had dilated further, closer to needing to push, “and Phainon trusts you as well. Please?”

“Of course I will. Now, try and breathe for me.”)

And shortly after, the baby was born, squalling and mewling with the strongest lungs of the Kremnoans.

“Well done, Mydei! You were right, she’s a girl,” Hyacine wiped the infant off with a soft towel, cleaning off the blood and other fluids before carefully placing her in Mydei’s embrace. “Ten fingers and toes, and a full head of white hair.”

Mydei was yet to return to his full lucidity, dazed from the pain and panting heavily as though he had just fought in a particularly difficult battle. *Well*, Hyacine thought, *technically he had been in a battle.*

Still, at the feeling of his daughter in his arms, her crying quietened by being close to her mother, golden eyes squinted open and trailed along her tiny body. Then after a pause, he mumbled, “...She looks like Phainon.”

What.

In Hyacine's opinion, newborn babies looked like raisins, too small and wrinkly to notice any major features other than their hair, *if* they had any. But, perhaps it made sense. After all, she had seen Mydei spend so long tracing the contours and lines of Phainon's features with his eyes in their daily life, loving and fond, so he was bound to recognise them, even in a smaller form.

“Nine months in *my* womb… and she looks exactly like her papa.” Mydei's words were that of disbelief, but his expression betrayed his delight, and he lifted the baby to plant a kiss on the downy strands of white.

For a moment, the room was quiet.

Then the baby began to shriek and Mydei flinched, writhing in agony as he looked tearfully at Hyacine, his expression pinched in pain once more. “Shit! What’s going on–?”

***

If someone asked Ica what their favourite food was, Ica would probably have to eat them. It was impossible to answer such a question.

If someone asked Ica what their least favourite food was, Ica would probably have to say panic. Ica hated the taste of panic.

Unfortunately, Ica was being spoonfed heaps of panic as they watched Phainon pace on the back of the dromas they were riding, staring frustratedly at the golden nymph in his hand which had just gone silent.

Meanwhile, the other man, Anaxa, sat there serenely, studying a piece of… *something*, while completely ignoring Phainon's terror. Ica found Anaxa to be an odd person, but he treated Ica with respect and always offered them food, so he must not have been that bad.

Anaxa had enlisted the help of Phainon and Ica to excavate a set of ruins in Tretos, claiming that 'the land that once birthed the infamous Tretos lion, must therefore be capable of birthing a mega-dromas.' Or something along those lines. Ica had been a bit distracted.

"Anaxa, what the fuck do I do?" Phainon was tearing at his hair, his face ashy as he tugged at the pale strands.

Initially, Anaxa was uninterested and merely corrected him in a flat tone. "*Anaxagoras*." But then he suddenly looked up in surprise, "Oh? Don't you always call me 'professor'?"

"Sorry I'm acting abnormally because my *wife* is in *labour,* and I'm stuck on a *dromas* in the middle of nowhere!"

"We're not in the middle of nowhere." A bored reply. "This is Tretos."

Ica thought that maybe, if the Tretos lion was still on the prowl, Phainon could have scared it off with the enraged shout he just let out. He looked close to tears, and then he decided he wanted to make Ica close to tears as well.

They could only squeak in alarm as quivering arms wrapped around their plush white form, and Phainon began rocking back and forth while squishing Ica in his arms therapeutically. "Ica, can you get me there?" His normally bright blue eyes were crazed, large as plates as he muttered "You're strong, right? You could fly me over," he punctuated those words with a little shake.

Ica was just a unicorn. "Doot-doot."

And then there was a whoosh of air, and an echoing meow as a familiar woman appeared on the dromas saddle.

"Heh, looks like the little lion is in labour." Cipher giggled at her alliteration, before snidely asking , "want me to help?"

She didn't wait for a reply – it was obvious what it would be – and only paused to tuck something in Phainon's coat. "This'll be my payment, 'kay? I want your baby to grow up thinking *I'm* the fun aunt."

Phainon didn't have a chance to reply to *that* either, before they were off, leaving Ica and Anaxa alone on a dromas in Tretos.

("..." A singular red eye stared into darkness.

"..." Two dark eyes stared into red.

"Right." Anaxa looked mildly uncomfortable, and he discreetly rifled through his pockets.

Ica had never eaten dromas before. But Ica was getting hungry.)

***

It was when Hyacine was peeling off her gloves after a successful labour and an easy delivery – heh, Phainon may have the title, but Hyacine was the *true* Deliverer – that Phainon *finally* showed up.

The doors of the medical bay burst open, one of them splintering at the force with which Phainon barged through looking absolutely dishevelled; his hair was windswept and his coat was ruffled, but most of all, his eyes were frantic with worry.

"Mydei! Where's Mydei?! Is he–"

And then his gaze landed on the bed, and he went stock still.

There Mydei was, looking unnaturally good for someone who had just given birth; Hyacine had helped change him out of his dirtied clothes, instead dressing him in a clean white robe, and he had a glow on his face as he smiled down at the not one, but *two* babies cradled in his arms.

Hyacine didn't need to have the gift of prophecy to foresee Phainon's reaction to the sight.

"D-dei…" He blubbered, the waterworks already starting as he stumbled over to the bed. For a moment, Hyacine's expectations were surpassed as he reached a shaky hand out to tuck a strand of blond hair away from Mydei's face and caressed his cheek.

Then he collapsed into a puddle on the floor, right on the pillow that Hyacine had set down in anticipation of this happening.

Phainon looked like an infatuated dog, kneeling beside the bed and raising his head onto the mattress to see their babies before breaking down in tears as he sobbed into the sheets.

"I was right." Mydei finally spoke, triumphant as he said, "Our first was a girl."

"Healthy… they're– are they healthy?"

“Twenty fingers, twenty toes and two sets of white hair.” At that, Mydei looked happy, and surprisingly proud, “Both our babies are like mini-yous, except our son has *my* eyes.”

Hyacine thought it was quite funny how out of two babies and a freshly postpartum mother, Phainon was the one crying the most.

Phainon's tears lessened, and he sniffled as he got to his feet to sit on the chair beside the bed – Hyacine had placed it there, anticipating this as well – stretching his hand out to card his fingers through Mydei's hair lovingly.

“How… how are there two of them?” He asked as he looked down at the babies, their little faces scrunched up in sleep.

Honestly, Hyacine mainly had herself to blame for that. The scanner she had used was slightly outdated, resulting in a more blurry image, and upon seeing the babies in the womb, curled up closely together, she had just assumed that it was one abnormally large baby. It wasn't that far-fetched considering how tall the parents were.

But she wasn't going to tell them that.

“One of them must have been hiding behind the other in the early scans.”

Maybe that was a sign to finally go and ask the Grove to develop their technology further.

“They’re so small…” Phainon stroked a finger across a chubby cheek, his eyes watering once more.

They’re so fat, Hyacine thought, because even if there were two babies and not one monstrously sized one, the twins were rather plump for their age. And Hyacine was used to looking at *Ica*, so clearly– wait. Where was Ica?

“Phainon,” The serious tone with which Mydei spoke snapped both Phainon to attention, only for his next words to be, “let’s have more.”

A full quint hadn't even passed. Mydei's insides were likely still wounded – though, perhaps his unique body helped hasten his healing – and he looked close to passing out from exhaustion.

He looked better than Phainon at least. Phainon started wailing again. “No more… I can’t do this to you again, honey,” he warbled, and Hyacine found it sweet how he cuddled Mydei close with his words.

“But they’re so cute,” Mydei cooed, and poked their son's tiny cheek, causing the baby to snuffle, “they look just like you.”

Again. Hyacine frowned as she stared at the man in confusion. *Newborns looked like raisins.*

“Imagine taking them around Okhema… the shopkeepers would spoil them, for sure,” Mydei was grinning as he spoke, potentially delirious from the aftershocks of pain, but still boundlessly happy. “And we could show them the chimaeras, let them play together…”

At his words, Phainon perked up once more and reached into his pockets. “O-oh. Cipher gave me,” he paused his words to sniffle, “Cipher gave me her gifts.”

And he tucked two fuzzy plushies beside their babies, a lion and a dog. The movement woke their daughter, and blue eyes met blue as she squinted at Phainon.

“Hello, darling,” he crooned, leaning down to press a warm kiss to his daughter’s head, giving her a wobbly smile when she made a small affectionate noise in return.

Hyacine found it funny how the babies hadn't even been named yet. Maybe she should say so, and remind the new parents that *no*, they couldn't keep calling their babies ‘sunshine’ and ‘darling’ forever, but she had a feeling that they wouldn't hear her. They were too enraptured with their newborns, already wrapped around their delicate little fingers.

It was alright, Hyacine was used to fading into the background whenever Phainon and Mydei were together. Besides, with her luck, she probably wouldn't be away from their growing family for long.

End Notes

does anyone have baby name ideas 💔💔💔 I was thinking Helios and Selene but idk if that's cliche but it's like… eclipse imagery… sun hiding behind the moon… lololol plus if they have a toy dog thats eclipse related because tiangou BUT THEN ALSO IN GREEK MYTH Helios and Selene have a sibling named eos (dawn)... third baby????

anyways i do have another fic idea to end of this cutesy little trio it will be phaidei with their babies BECAUSE IVE SEEN WAY TOO MUCH FANART OF THEIR CHUBBY LITTLE BABIES to not do anything

But i also have a couple of… multichapter!!! Ideas that i wanna put out so yeah idk see you around

twitter!!!

▶ extra notes:

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